

Sweat

The steam filled the room as Lucas poured another ladleful of water onto the burning hot coals. He struggled to keep his concentration as the room grew unbearably hot. Lucas slowly put the ladle down and raised his arms, slowly shaking his body and moving his arms in front of himself. He quickly punched the air, his fist breaking through the heat before him. He pulled his arm in and kicked backwards, the tips of his toes just barely touching the wooden wall behind him. He quickly reached down and put his full weight on his arm as he held himself momentarily in mid-air. The steam licked at his sides as Lucas remained motionless, held up by only one arm, suspended in the crushing heat of the room. He dropped to the floor and looked back to the long wooden ladle lying in a bucket of steaming hot water, then towards the wood door which led out of the sweat lodge.

The door to the sweat lodge slowly opened and Lucas stepped outside into the cold Swedish air, his toes touching the snow covered ground. He slowly made his way back to the cottage before him, focusing every muscle in his body so as not to break his focus and sprint back to the cottage. Lucas slowly pulled open the door, basking his body in a perfect warmth as his feet were lifted from the painfully cold snow to the soft, carpeted floor of the cottage. Lucas closed the door behind him and took a deep breath calming himself, before grabbing the towel to his right and covering his naked body.

"How do you feel now?" Hugo asked, his face hidden to Lucas behind a large newspaper. Lucas sat down in a fine rocking chair and rested his head on the furnished back.

"I can still feel their pain," Lucas spoke absently, his eyes looking up towards the rafters for no particular reason. Hugo lowered his newspaper and leaned forward in his armchair.

"You need to let their pain go, Lucas. You have done your time, you have been punished, I already have forgiven you," Hugo said almost pleadingly. Lucas simply continued to stare into the rafters. He had been released two years ago, but he was still in prison. Hugo sighed and laid his newspaper on the ground.

"Maybe you have not moved on because you do not want to move on, you do not want them to be forgotten," Hugo suggested, almost reluctantly. Lucas closed his eyes and saw two black shadows in front of him, and heard the thud of their soft bodies crashing into the hard metal of his car. Hugo bit his lip as he carefully crafted his next sentence. "If you think you are ready, I might have one last idea," Hugo said, each word slowly seeping out into the quiet of the cottage. Lucas's head shot forward as he eagerly awaited Hugo's final suggestion. Hugo smiled at Lucas's excitement.

"Have you heard of Skara?" Hugo asked. Lucas racked the back of his brain for that elementary education he had learned so long ago.

"The old city in South Sweden?" Lucas said unsurely. Hugo smiled once again and nodded.

"In that city, there is an old house said to free oneself of their past mistakes," Hugo said as he stood up and moved for his shoes. Lucas stood up with him.

"How come you never told me about this cathedral before?" Lucas asked, feeling somewhat betrayed.

"Well it is just an urban legend, but I figured it is at least worth a try if you feel nothing else has worked," Hugo said, grabbing a heavy coat as he slipped on a pair of snow boots. "I will

be waiting in the car while you get ready," Hugo said as he heaved open the cottage door, pushing aside the inches of snow blocking it as he did.

Their car rolled through the snow covered streets leading from the isolated cottage as snow caked trees who threatened to topple over at any moment slowly inched their way by. Little flakes of snow fell from the sky, a warning of something far worse to come. Lucas sat uncomfortably in the passenger seat of the car as Hugo focused intently on the road. Even though he was not the one driving, Lucas still felt as if he should not be allowed in that car. The road was long and winding, and what usually took a few minutes in fine weather, was taking five times that in the snow. Lucas looked down at his lap to calm himself down. The sky slowly turned from a blueish grey to a pale pink, and as they got onto the main road, Hugo kept his eye out for somewhere the two could spend the night.

As the sky turned black Hugo finally managed to pull over into the driveway of a motel. As Hugo stepped out of the car to stretch his back, Lucas ran into the motel, away from the car. The inside of the motel was painfully plain, unpainted wooden walls and a bare floor. A young boy, no more than fourteen or fifteen, stood slouched over the counter in the back of the small room. Lucas opened his mouth to talk to the boy but was interrupted by the boy opening a large book and lazily pointing to a spot on one of the pages for Lucas to write his name. Lucas closed his mouth and followed the boy's instructions, writing his name down and paying for two rooms, all without a word. The boy gave Lucas two keys, closed the book, and waved Lucas away. Lucas stepped outside to see Hugo waiting by the car.

Hugo said nothing and took the room key blankly, walking away to his cabin. Lucas followed suit and reached cabin number six. He opened the door, revealing a room equally as boring as the hotel's lobby.

The room was unpainted and completely empty with the exception of a bed, a nightstand, and a dresser. In the back of the room there was a door leading into a generic bathroom. Lucas laid down on the bed and looked to the ceiling, tired, but not wanting to fall asleep.

Crickets chirped from outside as the night continued on. Lucas stood up and looked around the barren room, trying to find something to preoccupy himself with. Lucas stepped into the bathroom and turned on the shower. Thin lines of water streamed out of the shower head above as Lucas began to undress and step into the tub. Lucas relaxed as he felt the cold water trickling down his body. A sound from outside quickly caught Lucas's attention and his head shot towards the door. Turning the shower off and stepping out onto the white tiled floor of the bathroom, Lucas wrapped a towel around himself and moved towards the door. The sound continued without end. It sounded like a roaring engine, and as he stepped closer, the smell of burning rubber wafted through the cracks in the door. Lucas slowly reached his hand out to the door knob and opened it a crack. The night was black, and the motel was gone, the only thing he could see was the outline of a car, crashed into the side of a tree. Just behind the car were two bodies, their figures mangled and bloody. The figure of a young Hugo ran over to the two bodies, screaming, and dropped to his knees.

The sound of furious knocking woke Lucas up. His eyes searched the room, seeing nothing but a nightstand, a dresser, and the bed he was currently lying on. Lucas slumped out of bed and opened the door to see Hugo, clearly very irritated. Hugo's face softened upon seeing the door open.

"We should leave, we have a long drive ahead of us," he said in a strangely calm voice. Lucas simply nodded and followed Hugo to his car, wishing he was already in Skara.

It was almost night again by the time they reached the brick streets of Skara. Their car slowed to a halt outside of a large cathedral with two tall pointed towers on each side. Lucas quickly got out of the car and followed Hugo as he made his way down the brick street. They continued down that road for minutes until reaching a small house. The house had no yard, and it barely had a walkway. Once they reached it, Hugo turned up the walkway and opened the door to the house.

"Are we allowed to just walk in there?" Lucas asked nervously.

"No one lives here," Hugo replied, "It is kind of like a national landmark open to the public." Lucas, still unsure of himself, followed Hugo into the unlit house.

The room they entered was dusty and barely finished. A rug in the middle of the room lay underneath a coffee table and between a couch and an old tube tv.

"So, do I just profess my guilt?" Lucas asked. Now that he was actually there, Lucas realized how unlikely the whole story was, and was becoming more skeptical by the second.

"I guess, the legend was not very specific about that," Hugo said as he searched around the room for something that would help them. Lucas got down on his knees and began to whisper to himself as Hugo continued to look around the room. As Lucas spoke, images flashed in and out of his mind, images of dead bodies and of a crying Hugo, seen through drunken eyes and the rear view mirror of his crashed car. The creaking of a wooden door broke through his thoughts and Lucas opened his eyes to see Hugo holding open a trapdoor, initially hidden under the rug in the middle of the room. Hugo looked at Lucas and smiled.

"I think this is it," he said in a giddy voice. Lucas crawled over and looked down into the dark hole below.

"Are you sure?" Lucas said in a wavering tone which barely could hide his dread and distaste.

"This is your last chance, do you really want to pass it up?" Hugo asked in an almost commanding tone. Lucas sighed and looked back down into the dark hole. There was a kind of ladder on one wall of the hole allowing Lucas to climb down. He touched one of the railings and its icy cold feel made Lucas shoot his hand back.

"Go on, I will be right behind you," Hugo said, reassuring Lucas. Lucas smiled up at Hugo and slowly made his way down into the dark hole. With each step he took, the cold air grew warmer, until it was almost unbearable. Lucas's feet finally touched solid ground and he turned to see a hallway lit by an unseen source. Lucas walked forward, the sound of Hugo's feet hitting the stone floor ringing out behind him. Lucas continued down the narrow path until he reached a small room with a low hanging ceiling. Above the doorway of the stone room there was a small metal handle, attached to something unknown. The heat was burning his skin now, and beads of sweat dripped down his forehead. Lucas walked into the small room and heard Hugo's footsteps stop. He turned back to see Hugo standing in the doorway. Hugo smiled.

"Hugo?" Lucas asked but Hugo simply laughed.

"You wanted to pay for their lives didn't you, so why not pay with your own," Hugo said through gritted teeth as he grabbed the metal handle above the doorway and pulled it down, bringing with it a heavy iron door. Lucas ran over to the door and tried to pull it up, but the metal

burned his hands and sent him tumbling backwards. Lucas screamed at the top of his lungs for Hugo to let him out but heard nothing in return.

The heat beat down upon Lucas and he fell to his knees. He put his hands down on the stone floor but that only succeeded in burning them more. He searched around the room for any way out but there was nothing. Lucas grabbed once again at the metal door and pushed up as hard as he could, the skin on his hands beginning to stick to the door and peel off. The door did not budge and Lucas fell backwards once again. He screamed for help, for someone to let him out, but still received no answer as he wasted away in that sweat box.

Hugo looked at the clock somewhat worriedly. Lucas was supposed to have come out by now. He walked over to the back door and grabbed a heavy coat before stepping out into the cold Swedish air. His boots crunched through a path covered in snow to the small wooden sweat lodge. He knocked on the door only to receive no answer.

“Lucas, are you still in there?” He asked loudly. Hugo pulled on the door handle but something had locked the door in place.